



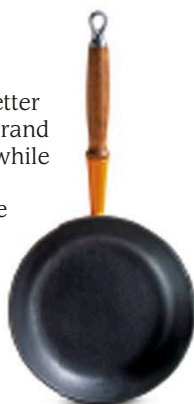
Fungi consume dead materials.

In 1939, Albert Einstein wrote to President Franklin Roosevelt, urging him to make building an atomic weapon a priority.

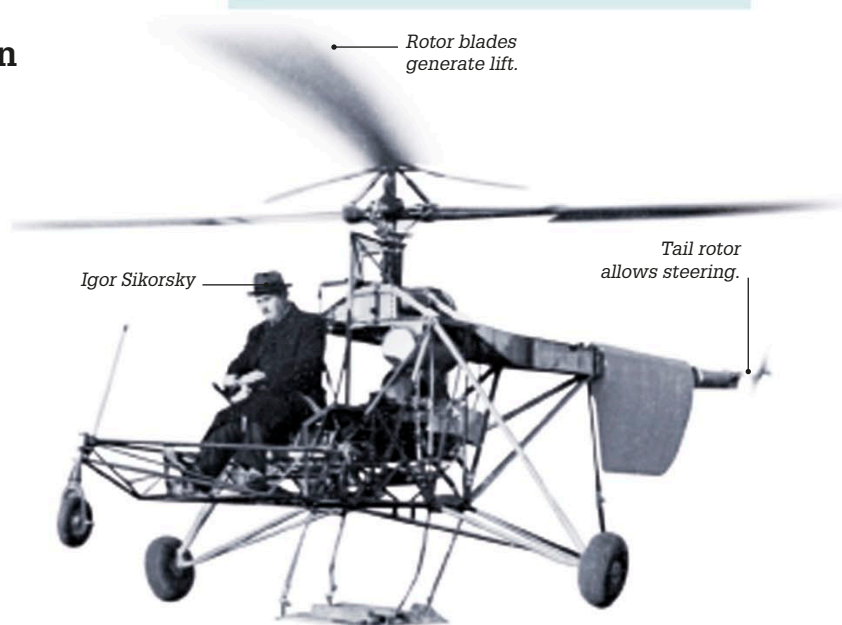
1938

Discovery of PTFE

American chemist Roy Plunkett discovered polytetrafluoroethylene (better known as PTFE, or by its brand name Teflon) by accident while developing a new fridge coolant. PTFE is unreactive and offers very low friction, making it great for nonstick cookware, and as a lubricant on machine parts such as gears and bearings.



Teflon-coated frying pan



1939

VS-300 on its first flight

First single-rotor helicopter

The first practical helicopter, VS-300, by Russian-American inventor Igor Sikorsky, made its maiden flight tethered to the ground in Connecticut. It flew freely in 1940. The helicopter's three rotor blades, powered by a 75-hp engine, generated lift. A smaller tail rotor enabled steering and balanced out the turning forces created by the main rotor.

1940



1938

Living fossil discovered

Looking for unusual specimens in a fisherman's catch on South Africa's east coast, museum curator Marjorie Courtenay-Latimer discovered an unusual fish that was later identified as a coelacanth. This fish was thought to have died out 65 million years ago. Coelacanths grow up to 6.56 ft (2 m) long and have four lobed fins that move alternately like a horse trotting.

“The most beautiful fish I had ever seen, five feet long, and a pale mauve blue with iridescent silver markings.”

Marjorie Courtenay-Latimer, 1938

1939

DDT

Swiss chemist Paul Hermann Müller discovered that DDT (dichloro-diphenyl-trichloroethane), first produced in 1874, is a powerful and effective insecticide (a substance that kills insects, which eat crops or carry diseases). It was used widely from 1943 onward to tackle malaria, typhus, and dengue fever, and later by farmers to rid their crops of pests. Fears about the chemical's harmful effects (see p.202) saw it banned in many countries in the 1970s.



Cropdusting aircraft spray DDT at the Congressional Airport, Washington D.C., c 1940